

Religion

As teens begin to form their own opinions, practice more independent thought, and develop their own moral code, they may start to explore different religious ideas, beliefs, and values.

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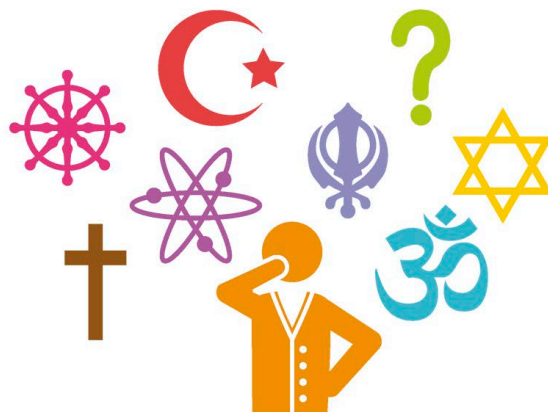
◀ 152–153 Discrimination

Young people and religion

Whether a person is brought up practicing a specific religion or not, it's normal for teens to question what they believe as they explore who they are and how they fit in the world. Some teens may investigate different ways to practice religion, or approach it differently from the traditions of their elders. Some may consider new aspects of spirituality, or lose their faith.

► Questions and answers

It is natural and healthy for teens to explore and educate themselves about the many different belief systems around the world.



Faith systems

There are thousands of faith-based belief systems around the world. Some are organized, some have huge followings, and others are comparatively small.

Buddhism

This 2,500-year-old religion originated in Asia. It is unlike most other religions in that it's not based on worshipping a god or gods. Instead, its 500 million followers aim to reach "enlightenment"—true wisdom about the meaning of life—by following the teachings of the religion's founder, Gautama Buddha.



Hinduism

The 1 billion followers of this 4,000-year-old religion have extremely varied traditions and worship different deities that represent different attributes of the supreme spirit, Brahman. Hindus believe that a person's soul is reincarnated and governed by karma—actions in this life and previous lives influence future ones.



Christianity

This monotheistic religion (belief in one god) is about 2,000 years old, with 2.2 billion followers. Christianity is based on the belief that Jesus Christ, son of God, was sent to Earth to save humanity from its sins. Christians believe in the teachings and the resurrection of Jesus, detailed in the Bible, Christianity's sacred book.



Islam

Islam's 1.6 billion Muslims believe in one god, Allah, who revealed teachings to the prophet Muhammad near Mecca, 1,400 years ago. These form the Qur'an, Islam's holy text. Muslims live by the five "Pillars of Islam": prayer, helping the needy, declaration of faith, fasting, and pilgrimage to Mecca.

